MURDERCRAB

DEEP-SPACE SHELLFIRE • CHERRY FEVE

1 PLAYER / 2 PLAYER ALTERNATING

5 STAGES + TRUE LAST BOSS

MASTER THE CHERRY CHAIN!

PLAYER'S MANUAL

Throwback Pack-In / Strategy-Zine Edition

PICO-8 ARCADE SHOOTER

INSIDE COVER

Launch Briefing

What this book is for and where to begin

MurderCrab is built like a little cabinet you keep coming back to: 3 credits per visit to the title screen, 5 stages of escalating shellfire, bombs that clear the screen and hammer bosses, cherries that push your multiplier upward, and a True Last Boss reserved for clean-credit pilots.

This manual is split like a deluxe 16-bit booklet: part instruction manual, part magazine insert, part operator catechism.

QUICK START

Press START. Launch on one credit. Hold shot. Bomb before regret. Collect cherries in sequence.

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MISSION BRIEF

The Outer Shells Have Opened

A cursed frontier, one impossible craft, five war-zones to cut through.

At the edge of charted space, dead stations and broken fortresses have become nesting ground for a proliferating mechanized crab-host. Their fleets descend in waves. Their artillery blooms in cruel geometries. Their strongholds molt, reform, and harden.

From a final strike hangar comes one answer: MURDERCRAB — a compact weapons platform with impossible output and a pilot half-mad enough to fly it into the choke of the swarm.

Your orders are simple:

- Break the outer formations
- Ruin the nest chain
- Survive five stages
- Face whatever still waits beneath the shell

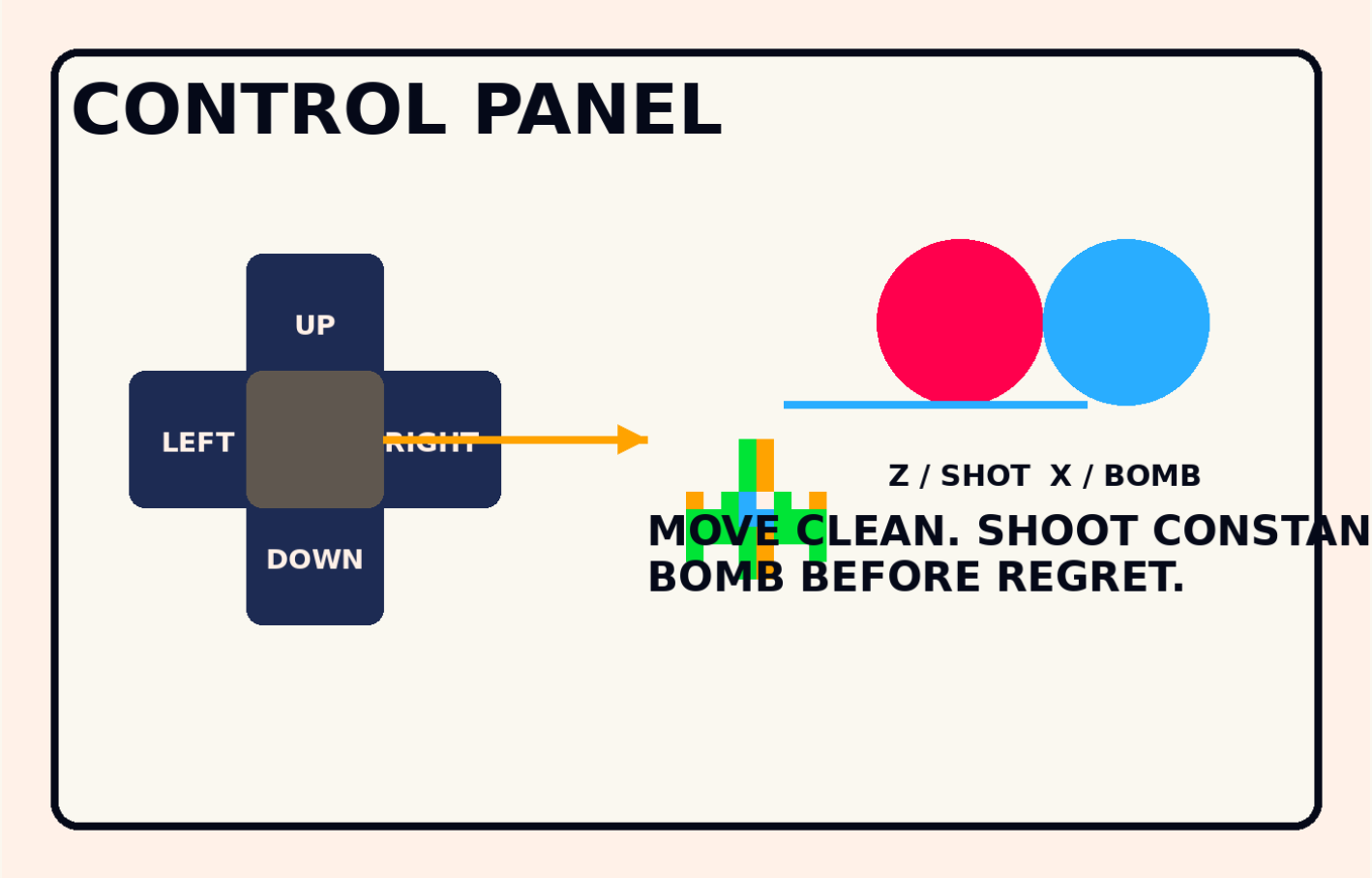
FIELD NOTE

The enemy does not advance like an army. It spreads like a bad idea.

CONTROL PANEL

Three Inputs. No Excuses.

Move clean, shoot constantly, bomb before panic turns into wreckage.



MOVE
Guide the craft through lanes, aimed fire, and ugly traffic.

SHOT (Z)
Twin forward volleys. Tap for measured bursts or hold for rapid fire.

BOMB (X)
Clears bullets, deletes normal enemies, and chunks bosses for 30 damage.

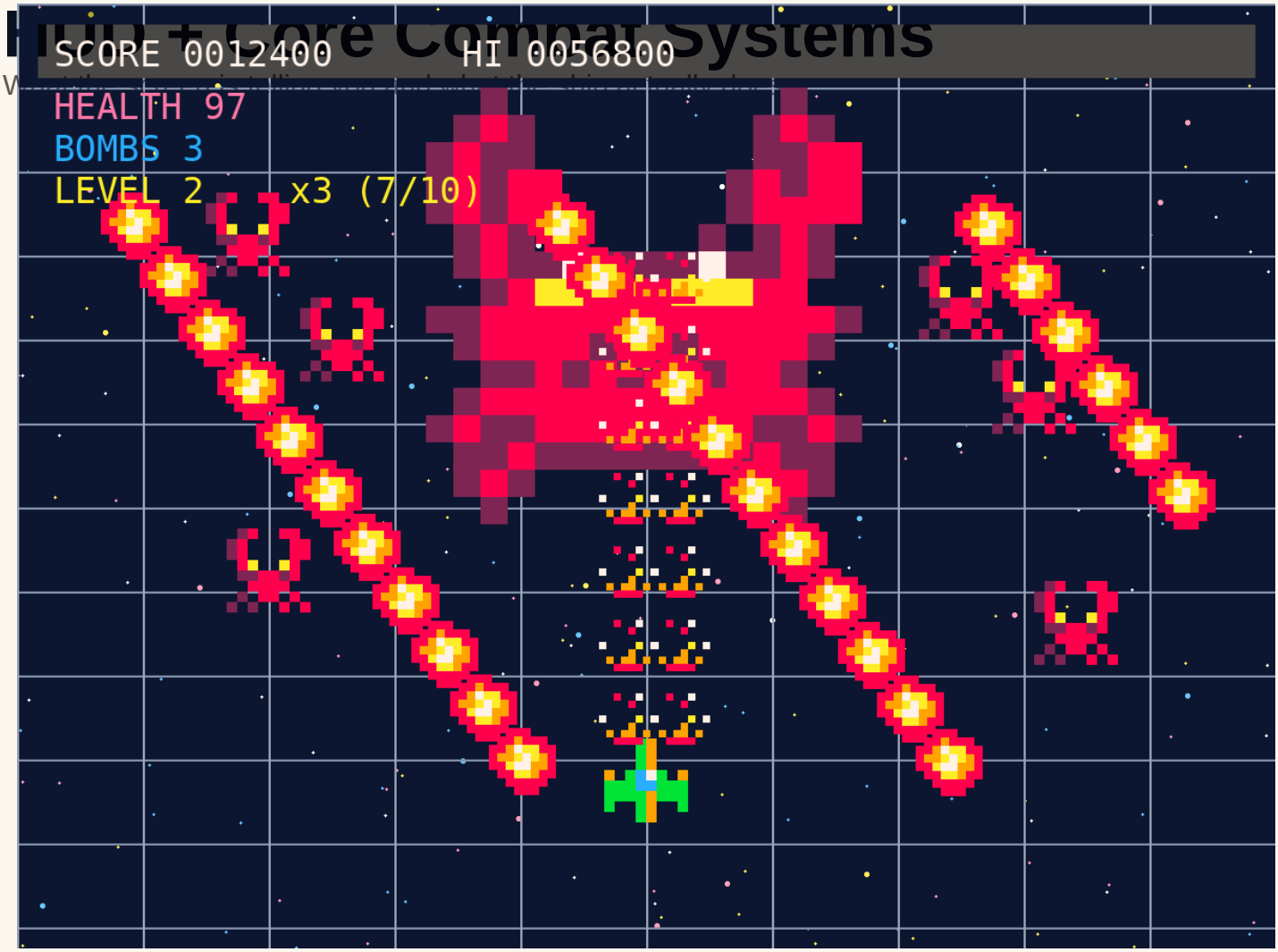
No focus mode. No charge shot. No excuses hidden in a sub-menu.

OPERATOR TIP

Beginners over-move. Good players move enough. Great players move exactly once.

READOUT

HUD + Core Combat Systems



- HEALTH starts at 100. A hit costs 1. Pickups can push you above base.
- BOMBS start at 3. There is no hard cap.
- Cherries are worth 100 points times your multiplier and increase streak progress.
- At 10 cherries in sequence, your chain matures and the multiplier rises.
- Continuing restores only 3 HP, resets streak + multiplier, and locks the True Last Boss.

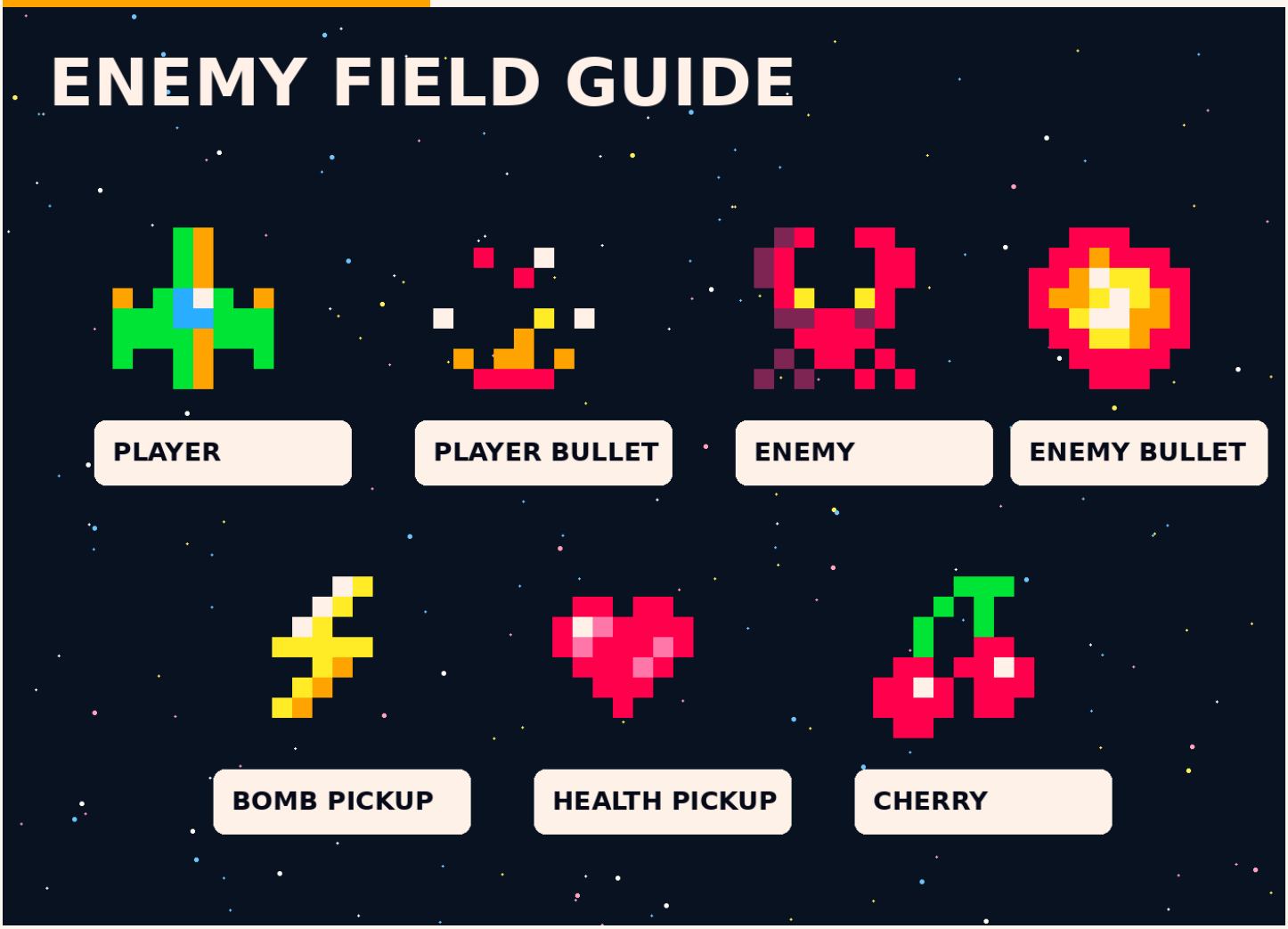
The player hitbox for bullets is a tight 2×2 box centered inside the ship sprite. That's why the gaps are mean, not impossible.

BOMB DOCTRINE

Bombs are not an apology. They are a conversion mechanic. Use them before death, not after regret.

HITBOX TRUTH

If a gap looks stupid but feels plausible, trust the tiny box in the middle of the ship.



Destroyed enemies burst into cherries with a 90% chance, and a small chance to also drop HEALTH or BOMB pickups. Cherries only live for 30 frames before blinking out. They are attracted to the ship at close range, but not enough to forgive a bad route.

This means every pickup asks the same question:
Can you keep the chain without breaking the run?

A clean player doesn't lunge for every item. A good scorer knows which items are structurally free and which ones are a trap wearing fruit colors.

CHERRY LAW

Chasing a cherry that kills you is not scoreplay. Preserving the route usually preserves more score.

CONTINUE PENALTY

Any continue resets multiplier and streak. It is enough to see what's ahead, not enough to keep dignity intact.

ENEMY FIELD GUIDE

Read the Screen, Not the Panic

Threat language matters more than raw density.

POPCORN ENEMIES — Route glue. Kill quickly or they become level design.
AIMED FIRE — Let it gather, then leave it behind.
STATIC GRIDS — Pre-set geometry. Read lanes and commit.
KAMIKAZE BODIES — The crash check uses the full ship sprite, not the tiny bullet hitbox.
BOSSES — The game speaking clearly and at length.

FIELD NOTE

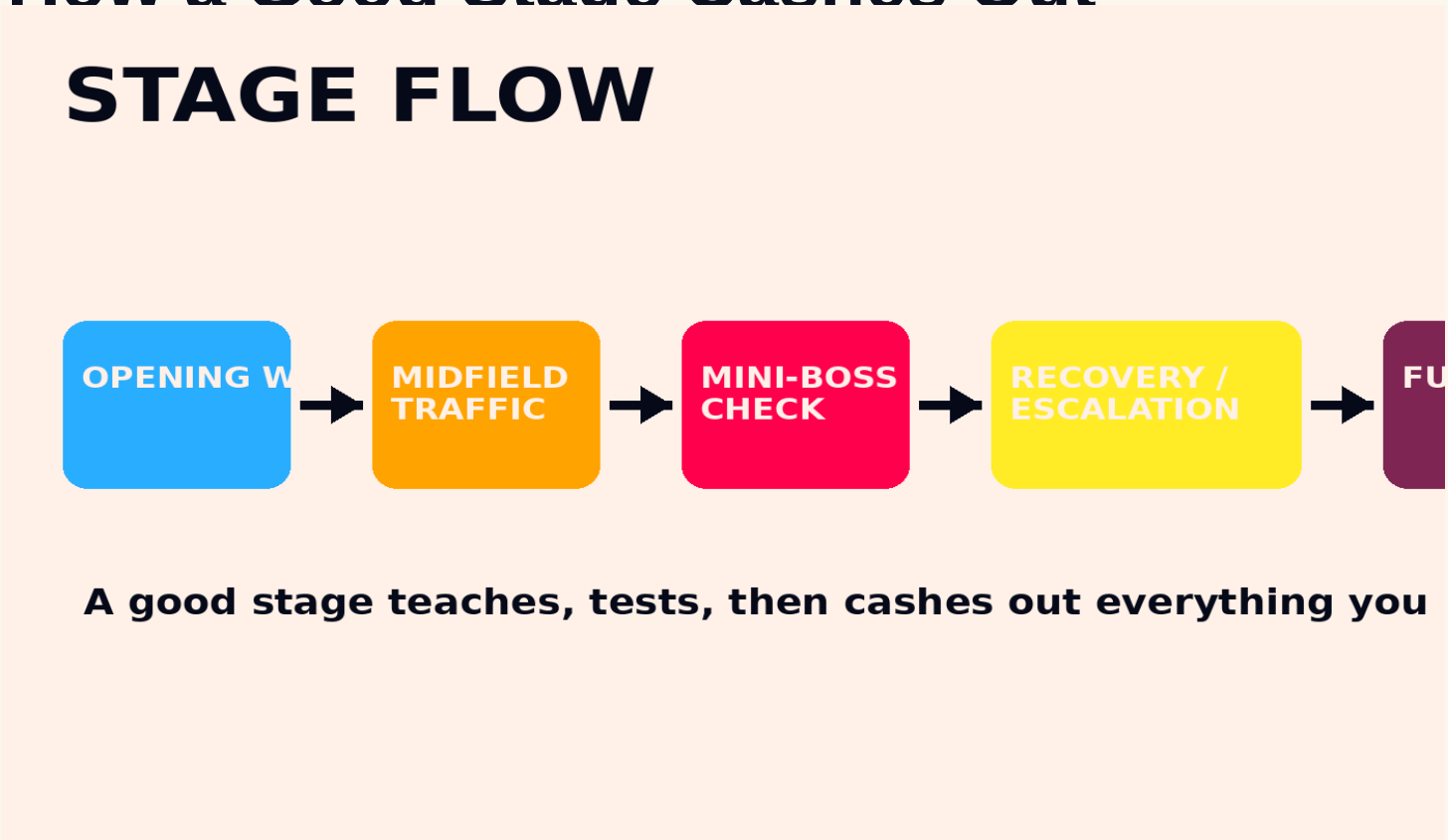
Most 'reflex deaths' are actually positioning errors from one or two seconds earlier.

READABLE DENSITY

Dense play becomes fair when the player can tell what is aimed, what is fixed, and what must die first.

STAGE ANATOMY

How a Good Stage Cashes Out



MurderCrab has 5 stages. Each stage contains an opening wave, an escalation section, a mini-boss check, a short recovery or pressure rebuild, and one full boss.

Stage 1 teaches lane control and early cherry rhythm.
Stage 2 increases density and asks for cleaner threat reading.
Stage 3 is a pressure chamber: stronger route memory, better side entry.
Stage 4 is the breakpoint where tourists and operators separate.
Stage 5 is the maw — the whole game compressed into one final gauntlet.

STAGE RULE

A good stage does not merely get harder. It teaches, checks whether you learned, then punishes the old habits you failed to shed.

BOSS DOCTRINE

Mini-Bosses, Full Bosses, Final Judgment

Short checks, long verdicts, and one condition for higher glory.

Every stage ends twice: once with a compact doctrine check, then with a full-screen conversation.

Mini-bosses test whether the player understood the stage's dominant lesson. Full bosses ask whether the player can synthesize it under pressure.

TRUE LAST BOSS CONDITION
The hidden sixth fight is not for everybody. Reach the end without

CLEAN CREDIT

No-continue play is not just survival prestige. It is the gate to the final layer of the run.

BOMB HONOR

A bomb that preserves a clean credit is usually smarter than dying pretty.

SCORE SCHOOL

Survival Is the Floor

A route proves you can drive.

MurderCrab is playable as a straight clear game, but it only becomes itself when the player starts thinking in route terms.

The score layer rewards:
- steady destruction
- cherry collection
- multiplier protection
- composure under pressure

To score higher:
1. stop improvising early sections
2. keep the cherry chain alive where it is actually cheap to do so
3. know when survival preserves more score than vanity
4. treat bombs as strategic insurance, not spiritual failure

SCHOOL OF THE JAM

Practice small sections until the good route is no longer hypothetical. Then connect them. Then perform.

REPLAY LITERACY

Replays are not cheating. They are how players inherit good ideas instead of wasting months reinventing bad ones.

How to Train Without Lying to Yourself

Drill what you cannot do. Stop congratulating what you already can.

A productive practice loop looks like this:

- isolate the ugly section
- learn enemy entry order
- decide where the safe space actually is
- repeat until your movement stops feeling emotional
- reconnect the section to the route

Target habits:

- no deaths with bombs in stock
- early-stage consistency
- calmer item collection
- better boss familiarity
- fewer meaningless movements

COLD TRUTH

The best runs often feel boring until they suddenly do not.

ANOTHER TRUTH

If the screen becomes unreadable, your positioning failed before your reflexes did.

HANGAR EDITOR

A beginner fears the end. An advanced player fears throwing away Stage 1.

GLOSSARY

Terms Worth Knowing

Community language helps the game stay legible.

1CC — one-credit clear
ROUTE — the repeated path through a section
POPCORN — low-end enemies dispatched quickly
AIMED — fire directed at the player's position
HERDING — guiding aimed shots into manageable shapes
MICRODODGE — tiny movement through tight gaps
PANIC BOMB — bomb used under immediate threat
NO-MISS — clearing a section without dying
NO-CONTINUE — finishing without spending another credit
TLB — true last boss

Design inspiration for this mock manual came from 16-bit instruction booklets and player's guides, especially Sega Genesis and SNES examples that combine startup warnings, boxed callouts, lore spreads, and practical play guidance. For shoot-'em-up lineage, the layout also leans on the culture of superplays, score

WHY THIS FORMAT

A good manual should teach systems, mood, and values at the same time. Otherwise it's just packaging.

NEXT STEP

Drop in real screenshots, final boss names, canon stage titles, and generated key art to turn this from a handsome mock booklet into the final artifact.